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EDUCATORS' EVOLVING ATTITUDES TOWARD AI: ANALYSIS OF DISCUSSIONS FROM R/TEACHERS AND R/PROFESSORS

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Abstract

As artificial intelligence (AI) plays an increasing role in society, educators face growing pressure to incorporate AI-driven tools into their classrooms. While these tools promise to enhance teaching and learning, their true effectiveness is best understood through the perspectives of the educators who use them. This study examines educators' attitudes toward AI by analyzing discussions in two popular Reddit communities: r/Teachers and r/Professors. We begin by analyzing the overall sentiment of 420 AI-related posts and their respective first-level comments using the Valence Aware Dictionary and sEntiment Reasoner (VADER). Notably, from January 2023 (shortly after ChatGPT became mainstream) to March 2025, we observe opposite trends in sentiment: a decline in positive sentiment for r/Teachers (from 84% to 71%) and an increase for r/Professors (from 62% to 82%). To better understand educators' attitudes, we apply BERTopic to posts and comments to identify key themes within AI-related discussions across both communities, resulting in six shared themes. We then conduct sentiment analysis on the representative posts and comments associated with each theme to examine educators' attitudes in these areas more deeply. Our findings suggest that while educators generally express positive attitudes toward AI across the identified themes, there is notable variability in sentiment within two specific areas: communication and neurodiversity. By identifying these areas of variable attitudes, this study provides a starting point for future research aimed at understanding the challenges and barriers educators currently face in adopting AI. These insights can inform the design of more effective AI adoption strategies in education.

Keywords: AI in education, sentiment analysis, topic modeling, reddit discourse.

1 INTRODUCTION

The potential for AI to improve education is vast, from automating grading and facilitating instruction to providing personalized learning experiences [1]. Yet despite the rapid development of AI tools, integrating them into classrooms remains a complex challenge. Educators continue to face persistent barriers to adoption, including personal barriers (*e.g.,* limited knowledge or confidence), technical constraints (*e.g.,* inadequate internet access), and organizational challenges (*e.g.,* lack of or inadequate professional development (PD)) [2, 3]. Crucially, educators' perceptions and attitudes toward these technologies play a pivotal role in determining whether AI is embraced or resisted [4]. Gaining a deeper understanding of how educators view and engage with AI is essential for reducing these barriers and enabling more effective and equitable implementation across educational settings.

To understand educators' attitudes toward AI, it is essential to gather insights directly from them. While prior research has used interviews and surveys to capture educators' perspectives [1, 4], such studies often rely on small sample sizes and limited demographic reach. However, improving AI adoption across education requires a broader view that includes educators across diverse grade levels, subject areas, institutional types, and geographic regions. In this study, we leverage social media to access a wide range of educator voices and explore their attitudes toward AI at scale.

We use Reddit [5], a community-based social media platform, to explore discourse around AI in education and gain insights into educators' attitudes. Reddit is a widely used platform for informal, candid discussions, making it a valuable source of social data for social scientists and researchers [6, 7]. In particular, we focus on two popular communities within Reddit, r/Teachers and r/Professors, which are frequently cited in educational research due to their active communities and rich content [8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15]. These communities host discussions that reflect the diverse perspectives and experiences of educators across various educational settings, allowing us to capture a range of attitudes toward AI in education.

To analyze AI-related discussions within these communities, we apply sentiment analysis using the Valence Aware Dictionary and sEntiment Reasoner (VADER) to assess the overall sentiment of posts and comments, followed by topic modeling with BERTopic to identify key themes discussed. Finally, we once again apply sentiment analysis specifically on the posts and comments associated with each theme to more deeply examine educators' attitudes within these key discussion areas. In doing so, we address the following research questions (RQ) in this paper:

- *RQ1*: What are teachers' and professors' attitudes toward AI in education, and how have these attitudes evolved since AI became mainstream?
- *RQ2*: What do educators' attitudes toward AI reveal about the barriers to AI adoption in schools and universities?

2 RELATED WORK AND THEORETICAL FRAMEWORKS

Our work is informed by insights from prior research on educators' attitudes toward AI, the challenges of adopting AI tools in education, and the use of Reddit data to explore education-related discourse.

2.1 Educators' Attitudes Toward AI

AI has been developed to support a wide range of educational tasks, including automating grading, offering intelligent tutoring, providing constructive feedback, facilitating instruction, and creating judgment-free learning environments [1]. However, the adoption of these tools in classrooms depends on educators' attitudes toward AI in education [1, 4]. A 2023 study involving 28 educators identified four key themes shaping these attitudes: pedagogical impacts, ethical and social considerations, technological challenges and opportunities, and overall perceptions of AI in education. The researchers found that while teachers recognize AI's potential to enhance instruction and streamline tasks, concerns such as limited PD can hinder positive attitudes [4]. A 2024 study reinforced this limitation, finding that higher levels of digital competence were associated with more positive teacher attitudes toward AI [16].

These findings align with the Technology Acceptance Model (TAM), which posits that individuals' willingness to adopt new technologies is primarily influenced by their perceived usefulness and perceived ease of use. In educational contexts, teachers are more likely to embrace AI tools when they believe these technologies can meaningfully enhance their instructional practice and when they feel confident navigating them [17]. PD programs aimed at increasing teachers' acceptance of AI have begun to emerge, such as [18], but they remain limited in scope. This highlights a major limitation of existing studies on AI in education; relatively small sample sizes and narrow participant demographics. In our study, we address this gap by exploring educators' attitudes using data from a larger, more diverse population through social media.

2.2 Barriers to AI Adoption in Education

Despite the growing interest in AI tools for education, several barriers hinder their widespread adoption in classrooms, including personal, technological, and organizational challenges [2]. Personal barriers may include teachers' lack of confidence in using AI tools or concerns surrounding their impact on pedagogical practices. Technological barriers can involve limited internet access or limited technical support. Organizational barriers may include resistance from school administrations or a lack of clear policies around the integration of AI in teaching and learning. While PD can help address some of these barriers, there is also a growing need for policymakers and educators to develop targeted strategies that ensure equitable access to technology and facilitate AI integration in classrooms [3]. But to do so, a deeper understanding of these barriers from the teachers' perspective is crucial. In our study, we aim to explore the barriers educators' face by leveraging social media data to gain honest, unfiltered perspectives from teachers.

2.3 Reddit as a Data Source for Educational Research

Reddit [5] is a social media platform and online forum where users share and discuss content across a wide range of topics. It is organized into communities called *subreddits*, each centered around a specific topic. Within a subreddit, users can create posts and comment on others, often asking questions, offering advice, or sharing personal experiences. To encourage quality discussions, Reddit uses a voting system where users upvote helpful posts and comments, and downvote unhelpful ones. A post or

comment's visibility is influenced by its vote count as well as the number of comments it receives, the age of the post or comment, and the relative rarity of its words [19].

Subreddits provide a wealth of social data (*i.e.,* publicly available data shared by social media users). Social data is often seen as providing some of the most honest and unfiltered perspectives [6]. It has also been considered a viable and cost-effective alternative for high-quality data [7], especially for social scientists and researchers studying the behaviors, opinions, and interactions within communities [20].

Among the many communities on Reddit explored by social scientists, those centered around education are especially active and content-rich. One such example is r/Teachers, a subreddit "dedicated to open discussion[s] about all things teaching." With 1.5 million members (as of March 2025), most of whom are K-12 educators, it ranks in the top 1% of all subreddits. Prior research has analyzed discussions in r/Teachers to explore advice-seeking and giving among teachers [8], social-ecological challenges in education [9], the role of affinity and anonymity in supporting early-career teachers [10], teacher self-directed learning [11], and concerns about online classes [12].

r/Professors is another subreddit centered around education, specifically higher education. With 157,000 members (as of March 2025), it ranks in the top 2% of all subreddits. Prior research has analyzed discussions to explore professional purposes in higher education [13], stress within academic communities [14], reactions to generative AI [15], and concerns about online classes [12].

Two common approaches to analyzing Reddit discourse include sentiment analysis and topic modeling.

2.3.1 Sentiment Analysis

Sentiment analysis is a natural language processing (NLP) technique used to classify the emotional tone or attitude expressed in text, typically as either positive, negative or neutral. Common approaches for sentiment analysis include lexicon-based methods, machine learning (ML) models, and hybrids. The choice of method largely depends on the type, size, and amount of text. For example, while ML approaches can be highly effective for a broad range of text, they often require substantial amounts of training data. In contrast, lexicon-based approaches are a lightweight alternative that can perform reliably on small text (*e.g.,* social media posts and comments) without needing training data [6].

Lexicon-based sentiment analysis uses a predefined dictionary or corpus, known as a *lexicon*, where each *token* (*e.g.,* word) is assigned a *sentiment score*. For example, VADER [21], a popular social media sentiment analysis tool, uses a lexicon where words are scored on a scale from –4 (extremely negative) to +4 (extremely positive). To analyze text, a *compound score* is calculated by aggregating the sentiment scores of each individual word in the text. This compound score is then normalized to a range between -1 and +1, and based on this normalized score, the text is categorized as having either positive (score ≥ 0.05), negative (score ≤ –0.05), or neutral (scores between –0.05 and 0.05) sentiment [21, 6].

Lexicon-based approaches, such as the one used by VADER, are particularly well-suited for social data. VADER is designed to handle the informal and expressive nature of online text, including initialisms, acronyms, slang, emoticons, and emojis [21]. Its strengths have made it a popular choice for analyzing Reddit discussions, including a 2023 study where researchers examined conversations surrounding online classes in r/Teachers and r/Professors (among other subreddits) [12]. Among lexicon-based approaches, VADER is considered one of the most reliable tools for analyzing Reddit social data [22].

2.3.2 Topic Modeling

Topic modeling is a ML technique used in NLP to discover hidden themes or topics within a collection of texts. It's useful for organizing and summarizing large amounts of text, making it easier to automatically extract insights. There are two main paradigms of topic modeling: *probabilistic* and *embedding-based*.

Latent Dirichlet Allocation (LDA) is a widely used probabilistic topic modeling technique that represents each document as a mixture of topics and each topic as a distribution over words [23, 24]. Although LDA has been applied to social data such as Reddit posts and comments [12], LDA is generally more effective for longer, well-structured text [24]. This is because LDA relies on identifying meaningful *word co-occurrenc*e patterns (*i.e.,* how often and in what context specific words appear together), which are more prevalent in longer documents. In contrast, short and informal texts like social media posts provide fewer opportunities for words to co-occur, making it harder for LDA to infer coherent topics. Additionally, as a bag-of-words model, LDA ignores grammar, word order, and semantic context. It also assumes topics are uncorrelated, which is often not true, and it requires careful preprocessing (*e.g.,* tokenization) and parameter tuning (*e.g.,* number of topics), which can limit its practicality for informal text [25].

BERTopic is a newer embedding-based topic modeling technique that uses transformer-generated text embeddings and clustering algorithms to identify topics. Unlike LDA's bag-of-words approach, BERTopic uses a pre-trained language model to generate semantically rich embeddings that capture meaning and context [23, 24]. These embeddings allow BERTopic to more accurately capture the relationships between words, making it well-suited for various types of text, including short, informal text [26]. While some preprocessing may be necessary, BERTopic is less sensitive than LDA in this regard. For these reasons, BERTopic has become a popular tool for analyzing Reddit social data, with applications ranging from studies of technology bans in schools [27], reactions to generative AI [15], and the mental health of college students [28].

3 METHODOLOGY

To examine educators' attitudes toward AI, we collected and analyzed Reddit posts and comments from two educator-focused communities using a combination of sentiment analysis and topic modeling.

We collected data from two public subreddits, r/Teachers and r/Professors. Using the official Reddit API, we searched for posts containing the terms "AI" or "artificial intelligence." Posts were sorted by relevance using Reddit's built-in search function, and we collected the top results along with their corresponding first-level comments. In total, our dataset includes 420 posts and 22,294 first-level comments. All posts and comments are publicly available, and no identifiable user information was collected or included in our analysis. Table 1 shows a summary of the collected posts and comments.

Table 1. Summary of Reddit posts and comments. Length refers to the number of words (mean / median).

Subreddit	# of Posts	Post Length	# of Comments	Comment Length
r/Teachers	225	258 / 186	14,656	56 / 34
r/Professors	195	232 / 166	7,638	55 / 30
Total	**420**	—	**22,294**	—

We first conducted sentiment analysis using VADER to assess the overall sentiment of each post and comment. Specifically, we used the *vaderSentiment* Python library to calculate sentiment scores, and then aggregated these scores by year to analyze trends over time. We then applied topic modeling to uncover key themes in the discussions. As a preliminary step, we compared LDA (using the *gensim* Python library) and BERTopic (using the *bertopic* Python library) on a subset of 50 posts from r/Teachers. Consistent with prior research, BERTopic yielded more coherent results on the short, informal text typical of social media discourse. Based on this comparison, we applied BERTopic to all posts and comments to identify key themes. To improve the results, we removed stop words (*i.e.,* common words with little semantic meaning like "the," "a," and "and"), lemmatized words to reduce them to their base forms (*e.g.,* "learning" reduced to "learn"), gave more importance to AI-related terms (*e.g.,* "GPT" and "LLM"), and used a Maximal Marginal Relevance (MMR) model to improve topic diversity. Finally, we applied sentiment analysis again to posts and comments most relating to each theme to gain deeper insight into the attitudes educators express toward each of these key discussion areas. Figure 1 summarizes the methodology followed in this study.

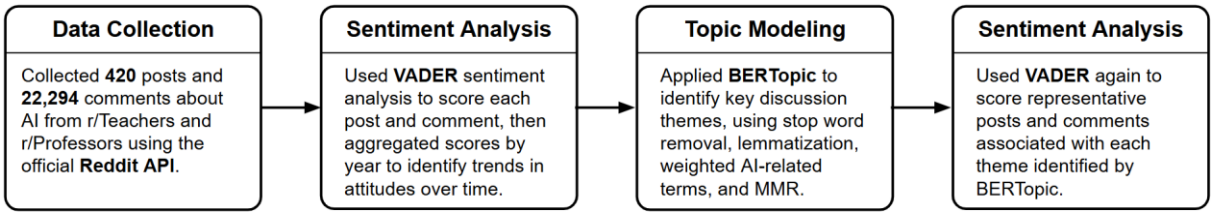


Figure 1. The methodology followed in this study.

4 RESULTS

Using sentiment analysis and topic modeling, we highlight educators' attitudes across key areas of discussion in the r/Teachers and r/Professors communities.

Table 2 summarizes the VADER sentiment analysis scores for posts and comments across r/Teachers and r/Professors. In general, the sentiment distributions for both posts and comments are predominantly positive. For posts, r/Teachers has a slightly higher proportion of positive posts (73%) compared to r/Professors (64%). However, for comments, r/Teachers and r/Professors have nearly the same proportion (51% for r/Teachers and 52% for r/Professors). Additionally, posts in both subreddits are generally more positive than comments. Specifically, 73% of r/Teachers posts are positive compared to 51% of comments, while 64% of r/Professors posts are positive compared to 52% of comments.

Table 2. Summary of sentiment analysis scores.

	Posts			Comments		
Subreddit	**Positive**	**Negative**	**Neutral**	**Positive**	**Negative**	**Neutral**
r/Teachers	164 (73%)	50 (22%)	11 (5%)	7,488 (51%)	4,593 (31%)	2,575 (18%)
r/Professors	124 (64%)	37 (19%)	34 (17%)	3,960 (52%)	2,070 (27%)	1,608 (21%)

To better understand the trends of sentiments toward AI across both communities, we examined sentiment distributions over time, focusing on two periods: prior to ChatGPT's release (late 2022) and the years following its mainstream adoption (2023–2025). Fig. 2 displays the sentiment distributions for r/Teachers (left) and r/Professors (right). Notably, from January 2023 (shortly after ChatGPT became mainstream) to current day (March 2025), we observe opposite sentiment trends: for r/Teachers, positive sentiment decreased from 84% to 71%, while for r/Professors, it increased from 62% to 82%.

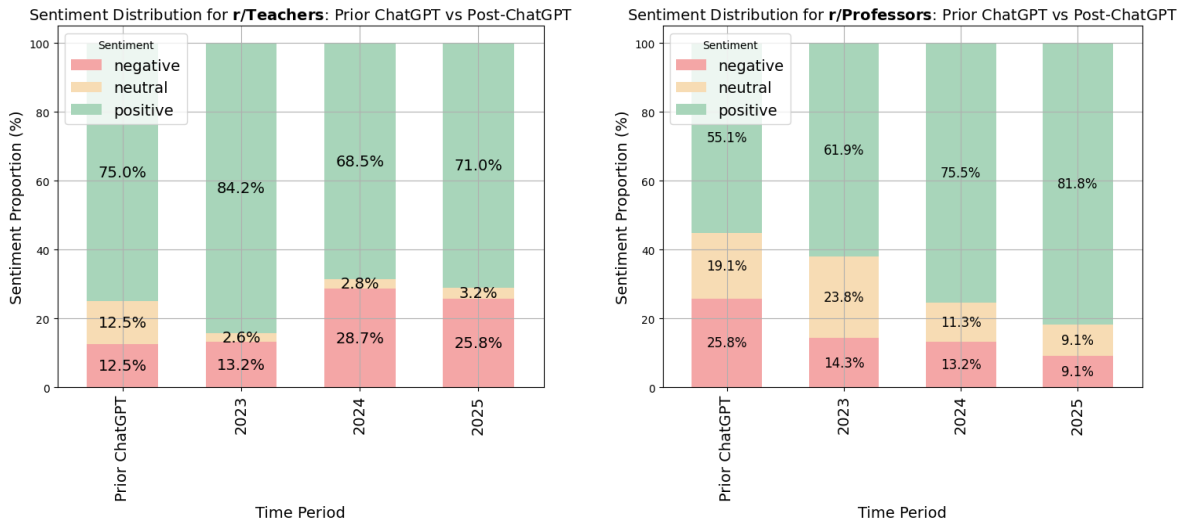


*Figure 2. Distribution of sentiment categories from **r/Teachers** (**left**) and **r/Professors** (**right**) discourse before and after ChatGPT became mainstream.*

While the overall sentiments for all posts and comments provides a broad view of educators' attitudes toward AI, understanding these attitudes more deeply requires examining the discussions themselves. Fig. 3 presents the top 12 most frequently discussed topics in r/Teachers (top) and r/Professors (bottom) discussions. These topics were identified using BERTopic. We then applied inductive reasoning to synthesize themes across the topics. We grouped the topics into broader themes based on their underlying meanings and context, drawing from representative posts and comments. Each topic was assigned to the theme it most closely represents, though we recognize that some topics could align with multiple themes. Through this process, we synthesized six key themes that are shared between the two communities:

1. *Large Language Model (LLM)*: Discussions surrounding the use of LLMs for generating content (by both students and teachers) and detecting AI-generated student submissions.
2. *Grading and Evaluation*: Discussions about using AI to help grade assignments and exams, as well as discussions surrounding creating submission policies (*e.g.* extensions and penalties).

3. *Academic Work*: Discussions focused on using AI to help create academic practice work for students, such as those involving mathematics, reading, and writing.
4. *Behaviors and Reactions*: Discussions about student and teacher behaviors in the classroom, including instances of laughing, yelling, and apologizing.
5. *Communication*: Discussions about both spoken and written communication, including using AI to assist with email conversations and messaging.
6. *Neurodiversity*: Discussions surrounding strategies for using AI to support neurodiverse students.

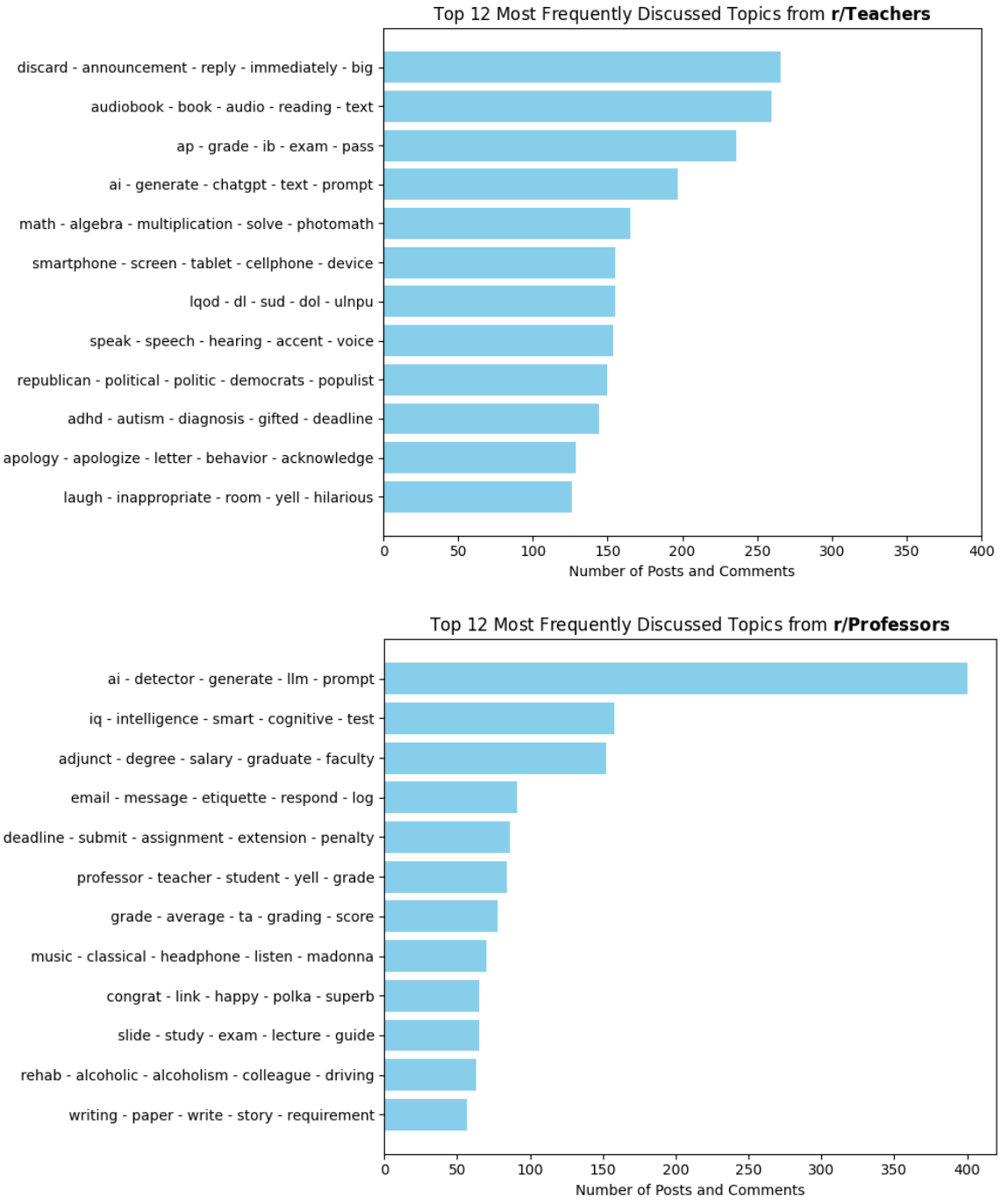


*Figure 3. The top 12 most frequently discussed topics from **r/Teachers** (**top**) and **r/Professors** (**bottom**). Each bar represents the number of posts and comments associated with a specific topic.*

Table 3 summarizes the themes shared across both communities, along with examples of topics associated with each theme. When inductively reasoning themes, we did identify some themes that are

unique to a single community. For instance, r/Teachers had several discussions about the use of various technologies allowed or not allowed in their classroom (*e.g.,* cell phones, tablets), while r/Professors had several discussions focused on academic roles and expectations (*e.g.,* expectations of faculty versus graduate student). Themes that were specific to a single community are not included in Table 3.

*Table 3. Summary of shared themes identified in both **r/Teachers** and **r/Professors**. While some examples could align with multiple themes, each is listed only once under the theme it most clearly represents.*

Theme	Examples	Subreddit
LLM	ai - generate - chatgpt - text - prompt	r/Teachers
	ai - detector - generate - llm - prompt	r/Professors
Grading and Evaluation	ap - grade - ib - exam - pass	r/Teachers
	grade - average - ta - grading - score	r/Professors
	deadline - submit - assignment - extension - penalty	r/Professors
	slide - study - exam - lecture - guide	r/Professors
Academic Work	math - algebra - multiplication - solve - photomath	r/Teachers
	audiobook - book - audio - reading - text	r/Teachers
	writing - paper - write - story - requirement	r/Professors
Behaviors and Reactions	laugh - inappropriate - room - yell - hilarious	r/Teachers
	apology - apologize - letter - behavior - acknowledge	r/Teachers
	professor - teacher - student - yell - grade	r/Professors
Communication	discard - announcement - reply - immediately - big	r/Teachers
	speak - speech - hearing - accent - voice	r/Teachers
	email - message - etiquette - respond - log	r/Professors
Neurodiversity	adhd - autism - diagnosis - gifted - deadline	r/Teachers
	iq - intelligence - smart - cognitive - test	r/Professors

Using these six themes, we applied sentiment analysis to representative posts and comments associated with each theme. These representatives were identified using BERTopic's get_topic_info() method. Table 4 summarizes the sentiment scores for each theme, calculated using the VADER sentiment analysis tool. While all six themes have a positive mean sentiment, three (Academic Work, Communication, and Neurodiversity) have significant variability (> 0.4) between their lowest and highest sentiment scores. Among these, Communication shows the widest range, with the lowest score having negative sentiment and the highest score having positive sentiment. Neurodiversity's range is within the positive range, however its lowest score borders on neutral sentiment. Academic Work has the least variability of the three, with both its lowest and highest scores having positive sentiments.

Table 4. Summary of sentiment analysis scores across shared themes. Themes with a Mean Sentiment marked with an asterisk have a range (difference between Highest and Lowest scores) greater than 0.4.

Theme	Lowest Sentiment Score	Highest Sentiment Score	Mean Sentiment Score	Mean Sentiment
LLM	0.560	0.660	0.627	Positive
Grading and Evaluation	0.799	0.999	0.945	Positive
Academic Work	0.361	0.856	0.564	Positive*
Behaviors and Reactions	0.751	0.991	0.910	Positive
Communication	-0.250	0.927	0.360	Positive*
Neurodiversity	0.077	0.998	0.538	Positive*

5 DISCUSSION

Our findings suggest that educators overall hold a positive attitude toward AI. This aligns with findings from [3], which reported that 59% of educators had either extremely or somewhat positive perceptions of AI. However, our study reveals a notable divergence between two educator communities. While positive sentiment has increased among higher education faculty (r/Professors) since ChatGPT became mainstream, K-12 educators (r/Teachers) have shown a decline in positive attitudes. Although prior work has explored educators' attitudes toward AI, such as [4], it does not directly compare attitudes across different educational levels. Our results begin to address this gap, suggesting that institutional context may shape educators' attitudes. [2] calls for future research to explore institutional differences influencing AI adoption, stating, "Institutions with well-defined policies, and ethical guidelines for AI integration, urge educators to embrace technology, however, in the absence of clear policies, guidelines, and support for AI integration within institutions educators restrain themselves from using AI technologies." Researchers of [29] examined AI policies at 102 institutions and observed that high schools are less inclined to develop such policies than higher education institutions. This is further echoed in [3] where the researchers observed that "some [K-12] educators may not be aware of whether such policies exist in their district, highlighting the need for greater communication and transparency regarding district policies." This disparity in institutional AI policies may help explain the divergent attitudes we observe between K-12 and higher education educators.

Our findings also highlight six key areas of discussion among both K-12 and higher education educators: LLMs, Grading and Evaluation, Academic Work, Behaviors and Reactions, Communication, and Neurodiversity. While all areas exhibit an overall positive sentiment, Communication and Neurodiversity show the greatest variability, with Communication having a negative lowest sentiment score and Neurodiversity having a near-neutral lowest sentiment score. While some research highlights AI's potential to support student communication and collaboration, such as [1] and [3], other studies point to educators' mixed feelings about using AI for communication tasks like email, including [15]. Again, these conflicting attitudes could relate to poor policies at institutions, with [15] stating, "One potential reason [for mixed feelings towards AI usage in personal communications] is that the lack of clear policy on whether certain usage is appropriate prevents students and faculty from discussing the productivity side of AI." Again, the lack of clear AI policies by institutions may explain the significant variability of sentiment regarding Communication and AI.

Regarding Neurodiversity and AI, [30] reviews current AI technologies used in special education and emphasizes that effective integration requires educators to be extensively trained through PD. Similarly, [4] notes that limited access to PD can hinder the formation of positive attitudes toward AI. Together, these findings suggest that without adequate support and training, educators may struggle to adopt AI tools that could benefit neurodiverse learners. Inadequate PD may explain the variability of sentiment in discussions concerning Neurodiversity and AI.

Based on our findings and alignments to existing research, we synthesize that there are two main barriers hindering educators' attitudes towards AI: unclear AI policies and inadequate PD. These barriers warrant further exploration to better understand how to create more effective AI integration strategies across education.

6 CONCLUSIONS AND LIMITATIONS

In this study, we used sentiment analysis and topic modeling on r/Teachers and r/Professors discourse to explore the attitudes of educators toward AI and the barriers causing negative or conflicting attitudes. While overall sentiment toward AI remains positive, the divergence between educator communities and the variability within key themes like Communication and Neurodiversity point to important barriers. Our findings suggest that unclear institutional policies and a lack of adequate PD may be contributing factors. As AI continues to enter classrooms in different forms, future work should further investigate these barriers to ensure that all educators are supported in adopting AI in their classroom.

One limitation of this study is that, while Reddit provides access to a large and diverse population, we cannot verify the demographics or roles of individual users. Although our aim was to capture broad perspectives through social media data, there is no guarantee this was fully achieved. Additionally, sentiment analysis tools like VADER may oversimplify nuanced or context-specific language when analyzing text. Manual analysis of posts and comments could offer deeper insight into the context and complexity of educator perspectives. In future work, we hope to incorporate this kind of analysis to strengthen our findings.

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